Galatians

Called by grace · Give God the glory · Session 2

FROM LAST TIME

Last time we heard Galatians 1:1–9. Jesus gave himself for our sins to rescue us. Paul is alarmed because the churches are turning toward a different gospel. Adding a requirement as the basis of acceptance before God distorts the gospel of Christ. We continue in that same letter.

READ TOGETHER — GALATIANS 1:10–24 CSB

10 For am I now trying to persuade people, or God? Or am I striving to please people? If I were still trying to please people, I would not be a servant of Christ.

11 For I want you to know, brothers and sisters, that the gospel preached by me is not of human origin. 12 For I did not receive it from a human source and I was not taught it, but it came by a revelation of Jesus Christ.

13 For you have heard about my former way of life in Judaism: I intensely persecuted God's church and tried to destroy it. 14 I advanced in Judaism beyond many contemporaries among my people, because I was extremely zealous for the traditions of my ancestors. 15 But when God, who from my mother's womb set me apart and called me by his grace, was pleased 16 to reveal his Son in me, so that I could preach him among the Gentiles, I did not immediately consult with anyone. 17 I did not go up to Jerusalem to those who had become apostles before me; instead I went to Arabia and came back to Damascus.

18 Then after three years I did go up to Jerusalem to get to know Cephas, and I stayed with him fifteen days. 19 But I didn't see any of the other apostles except James, the Lord's brother. 20 I declare in the sight of God: I am not lying in what I write to you.

21 Afterward, I went to the regions of Syria and Cilicia. 22 I remained personally unknown to the Judean churches that are in Christ. 23 They simply kept hearing, "He who formerly persecuted us now preaches the faith he once tried to destroy." 24 And they glorified God because of me.

Scripture quotations marked CSB are taken from the Christian Standard Bible®, Copyright © 2017 by Holman Bible Publishers. Used by permission. Christian Standard Bible® and CSB® are federally registered trademarks of Holman Bible Publishers.

A Servant of Christ

Part 1 · Galatians 1:10–14

THE GOSPEL DOES NOT COME FROM APPROVAL

Paul has just said that even he stands under the gospel. He now answers the suspicion that his message was shaped to win people over. He asks whether he is trying to persuade people or God, and whether he is still striving to please people. A servant of Christ does not make human approval the aim of the message.

The gospel he preaches is not of human origin. He did not receive it by trimming it to suit his hearers, and he was not taught it as his own invention. It came by a revelation of Jesus Christ. That is Paul's apostolic witness. We do not wait for a private revelation of our own. We receive this gospel in the apostolic Scriptures.

Then Paul tells what his former zeal produced. He persecuted God's church and tried to destroy it. He advanced beyond many of his contemporaries and was extremely zealous for the traditions of his ancestors. Jewish identity is not the enemy, and God's law is not a mistake. Impressive religious effort can still be aimed against the grace of Christ.

Approval can work quietly among us. We may want to sound assured, keep the peace, or be the woman others think of as spiritually steady. That desire can sand down what we say about Jesus, or push us to offer a story that will be admired. Serving Christ frees us to tell the truth. Another woman's confidence does not change the gospel. Our hope stays in Christ, who was revealed, rather than in how our faith appears beside hers.

DISCUSS

1. In 1:10–12, what is Paul unwilling to live for, and where does he say his gospel came from?
2. Where might the desire to be approved — by sounding assured, keeping the peace, or being well thought of — pull you to soften what Christ has done?

NOTES AND REFLECTION

Called by Grace

Part 2 · Galatians 1:15–24

GOD RECEIVES THE GLORY

The story turns on God's action. God set Paul apart, called him by his grace, and was pleased to reveal his Son in him, so that he would preach Christ among the Gentiles. His advancement did not earn the call. Grace reached him, and the churches who heard his story glorified God.

He did not immediately consult with anyone or go up to the apostles in Jerusalem. He went to Arabia and returned to Damascus. Three years later he spent fifteen days with Cephas and also saw James. He speaks with an oath because the churches need to know that his gospel came from Christ, not from a campaign to please one group or another. This is not a lesson in staying away from other believers. The next chapter will show him relating his gospel to the other apostles. The point here is the source.

The Judean churches did not know him by face. They kept hearing that the man who had persecuted them now preaches the faith he once tried to destroy. And they glorified God because of him. The end of the story is worship, not a testimony arranged so that Paul will be admired.

When we tell what God has done, comparison can slip back in: whose story sounds stronger, whose change looks cleaner, who seems further along. Grace gives a different use for a story. We tell the truth about mercy received, and we help one another notice God's work without ranking it. Encourage a sister by giving God glory for his grace in her, rather than measuring her journey against yours.

DISCUSS

1. How does 1:13–16 tell the story of Paul's change, and whom do the churches glorify in verse 24?
2. When you speak about what God has done, what helps the glory stay with him? How could you encourage another woman this week by noticing his grace in her?

PRACTICE THIS WEEK

Reread Galatians 1:10–24. When you notice yourself shaping your story so it will compare well, return to the God who calls by grace. Encourage one woman this week by naming what God has done, without measuring her against someone else.

PRAY

Father, thank you for calling us by grace and for revealing your Son. Free us from shaping our stories for approval. Teach us to tell the truth about your mercy and to give you glory for your work in one another. By your Spirit, make our encouragement faithful and kind. Amen.